

ACTIVITY 6.16

Homework activity: Sponsored content

1. Work with a partner to follow a number of influencers on a range of social media platforms. How often do they post sponsored content?
2. How often is this sponsored content labelled clearly?
3. What are the potential dangers for audiences when considering the reach and influence of TikTok stars?
4. Conduct some research and compile a list of the most dangerous products advertised on TikTok. What does this tell you about the potential for negative influence from individuals on TikTok?

Influence of media industries and institutions: How TikTok keeps your attention

TikTok is addictive. Its algorithm is designed to be so. While not all of its techniques are fully understood, what is known is that whenever a TikTok user logs into the app, they are shown eight videos from a range of topics. Based on what video the user chose, the algorithm shares another eight new videos in that genre. The algorithm also collects data about the user's device: account settings, captions, hashtags, language settings and location. TikTok then categorises the user into 'clusters' and keeps them in 'bubbles'.[19]

By providing users exactly what it thinks they want, TikTok keeps users engaged longer than any other social media app. All the while, it is collecting data.

In 2021, TikTok updated its privacy settings (which, of course, few of its users read) to enable it to collect biometric data. These are the fingerprints, 'faceprints' and 'voiceprints' of its users. This data is also analysed to optimise its algorithms.[20] What does TikTok want with such information? This, to date, has not been made clear.

A 2021 ABC documentary in Australia titled 'TikTok: Data mining, discrimination and dangerous content on the world's most popular app' spoke to two Australian teens who had begun to engage with the popular 'What I eat in a day' trend. TikTok's algorithm led both girls, who had pre-existing mental health conditions, towards more dangerous content that encouraged eating disorders. Both users ended up in hospital care, where with the help of psychologists, they were able to slowly re-engineer their TikTok algorithms.[21] It is also suggested by the documentary makers that the data is used by TikTok to gain a better insight into the personality, health, education and wellbeing of users, in order to improve the quality of content and engagement of its users.

ACTIVITY 6.17

Reflection

As a class, brainstorm the challenges of this type of data collection for individual users.

FOMO AND MENTAL HEALTH

More broadly, TikTok, as with other social media, has been accused of deteriorating the mental health of its users, specifically teenagers. One of the most noticeable aspects of social media is the Fear Of Missing Out (FOMO) it generates with users. FOMO is defined as:

> a pervasive apprehension that others might be having rewarding experiences from which one is absent. FOMO is characterized by the desire to stay continually connected with what others are doing.

FIGURE 6.41 A definition of FOMO quoted in Andre K Przybylski et al., 'Motivational, Emotional, and Behavioral Correlates of Fear of Missing Out', *Computers in Human Behaviour*, *ScienceDirect*, Vol. 29, Iss. 4, July 2013, pp. 1841–48

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Further research into FOMO and social media (in particular, TikTok) has shown it contributed to lower general mood, lower wellbeing and lower life satisfaction.[22] Think carefully about your own social media feeds. How often do influencers, friends and family that you follow post content that gives you the sinking sensation that you are not on holiday? Not wearing new clothes? Or having exciting experiences? It's natural for people to want to share their positive personal experiences; however, it is suggested that this can have a negative cumulative effect on viewers of the content.

In addition to this is the suggestion that TikTok's constant stream of seemingly perfect influencers of all genders can contribute to low self-esteem and self-image in young users. Combined with FOMO, it can contribute to a sense of loneliness and disconnection from social circles.

ACTIVITY 6.18

Reflection

Examine all that you have learnt about the promotion of 'outrage algorithms' and FOMO. What impact can these have on a user who is vulnerable and in poor mental health?

TikTok and conspiracy theories

Consider your response to the previous activity. How might TikTok affect vulnerable users if they were presented with an solution to their issues, regardless of how outrageous it may seem? **Conspiracy theories** have existed for decades yet have taken a much more prominent and dangerous role in modern society as they have crept into the mainstream media space. Social media has played a significant role in this. Via the darkest corners of the web, conspiracy theories that questioned the authenticity of the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020 and posited a supposed 'secret' world order that controls all human life found a home in websites like 4-Chan and 8-Kun.



FIGURE 6.42 Do you use TikTok?

For some time prior to the pandemic, YouTube was a popular home for conspiracy theory content, and its personalised algorithm sent more and more viewers of this content down the conspiracy theory **rabbit hole**. In the wake of the attack on the US Capitol building on 6 January 2021, YouTube, Facebook and Twitter reacted quickly to remove thousands of conspiracy-related posts, videos and accounts. However, in 2022, this type of content was appearing again in the mainstream, this time on TikTok.

conspiracy theories a belief that an event or situation is the result of a secret plan made by powerful people

rabbit hole a term to describe the internet's capacity to suck users into an extremely engrossing and time-consuming topic

Using variations of banned hashtags and keywords, videos promoting conspiracy theories appeared on TikTok in rising numbers in 2022. While TikTok made several announcements that this content is being removed, the accounts play a cat-and-mouse game with TikTok's content regulation and find new ways to outsmart it and post content. More broadly, the popularity of TikTok worldwide has led to it becoming the new home of misinformation on climate change, COVID-19 and the 2022 invasion of Ukraine. In September 2022, NewsGuard, an American watchdog for online misinformation, reported that the top 20 results in 27 searches for news stories on TikTok found that 19.5% of those videos contained false and misleading information.

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